

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

This work is an adaptation of Tyndale Open Study Notes © 2023 Tyndale House Publishers, licensed under the CC BY-SA 4.0 license. The adaptation, Aquifer Open Study Notes, was created by Mission Mutual and is also licensed under CC BY-SA 4.0.

This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Acts

Acts

The book of Acts has a central role in the New Testament. It connects the life of Jesus with the first Christian community. It also links the Gospels with the rest of the New Testament.

Acts shows how the Christian message was announced in both Jewish and non-Jewish (Gentile) settings. It highlights the key roles of Peter and Paul in spreading the good news throughout the Mediterranean world.

Acts tells the story of a living and active message. This message reaches outward to all people.

Setting

Luke wrote at a time when the good news about Jesus Christ was spreading from Jerusalem throughout the Mediterranean region. Luke was probably a Gentile (not Jewish), and his account of Christian origins reflects the needs and perspective of the wider world.

Luke began his presentation of the message of Christ with an account of the life of Jesus (the Gospel of Luke). In the book of Acts, Luke describes how the Christian faith extended across the Mediterranean region.

Luke wanted to show that God's love and mercy reach everyone. The apostle Peter told Cornelius, "God does not show favoritism" (10:34). Christ is the only one who can save (4:12). Everyone can believe in him for salvation and new spiritual life (see 16:30–31).

Jewish Christians tended to keep God's grace to themselves. But the church agreed that Gentile Christians have full inclusion in God's promises (see 15:1–31). The message of the forgiveness of sins and new life through Christ is for people from all nations.

Summary

The Holy Spirit filled and empowered the apostles and other followers of Christ. This was so they could fulfill the great commission to "make disciples of all nations" (Matthew 28:18–20). Acts specifically emphasizes the ministries of Peter and Paul (Acts 1:1–12:25; 13:1–28:31).

The book of Acts describes the spread of the good news about Jesus using a geographical sequence from Acts 1:8. The Christian message and community of Christians spread in Jerusalem (1:1–8:3). It went throughout Palestine and Syria (8:4–12:25). It then

reached the Gentile world throughout the Roman Empire (13:1–28:31).

The final word in the Greek text of Acts is *akōlutōs*, which means "without restraint" (28:31). This word recalls how the good news spread freely to:

- Jews (3:1–5:42),
- Samaritans (6:1–8:40),
- Gentiles who worshiped the God of Israel but did not fully convert to Judaism ("God-fearing" people; 8:26–40; 9:32–11:18), and
- Gentiles (11:19–30; 13:1–28:31).

Purpose of Acts

History

The book of Acts describes people, places, and events involved in the early spread of the good news about Jesus.

Geography

Acts describes how the good news spread from Jerusalem to Rome (1:8; 9:15).

Biography

Acts focuses on the ministry of Peter and Paul. Along with the apostle James, they led the early Christian movement. Other important early Christians, like Stephen, Philip, and Barnabas, also played key roles.

Evangelism

Evangelism means sharing the good news about Jesus with other people. It includes telling the story of Jesus, explaining what he taught, and inviting others to follow him. Acts provides plain examples of how Christian leaders shared the good news about Jesus with different audiences (see the speeches in chapters 2–5, 7, 10, 13, 22, 26).

Acts also shows that the good news is for everyone. It is not only for Jews but also for Gentiles (2:8–11; 8:26–40; 10:1–11:18). It is not only for men but also for women (5:14; 8:12; 16:13–15; 17:4, 12, 34; 18:26; 21:9).

Politics

Acts presents a strong defense of the Christian faith to both Jews and Gentiles. Christian leaders speak to Jewish audiences and to Gentile authorities (4:8–12; 7:2–53; 24:10–21; 26:1–23). Luke argues that Christianity should receive the same legal protection that Judaism already had. In the Roman Empire, Judaism was recognized as a *religio licita* (a permitted religion). Luke also shows that Christianity did not threaten the Roman government or public order (18:14–16; 19:37; 23:29; 25:25; 26:32).

Author

Luke traveled with Paul (see 16:10). He stayed with him in his later years (2 Timothy 4:11). Several passages in Acts appear in the first person (“we”; 16:10–18; 20:5–15; 21:1–18; 27:1–28:16). This suggests Luke was with Paul during those journeys. In Paul’s letter to the Colossians, he calls Luke “the beloved physician.” Paul also lists Luke as one of several non-Jews who were working with him (Colossians 4:11–14; see also Philemon 1:24). Paul appreciated Luke’s love and support as a loyal fellow worker and friend.

Luke probably wrote the Gospel of Luke. Both works share a consistent religious or theological viewpoint. Each book highlights the historical reality of God’s work in saving people. It emphasizes:

- the role of the Holy Spirit,
- the central place of prayer, and
- the importance of angels.

It also shows how Old Testament promises are fulfilled in the life of Jesus and in the Christian community.

Luke presents God as guiding the course of history to carry out God’s purpose.

Luke was a responsible historian in the Hellenistic world (the Greek-speaking culture of his time). He used careful historical methods and clearly explained how he worked. He wanted to write an accurate and orderly account of the beginnings of the Christian faith (Luke 1:1–4).

When other historical sources can confirm Luke’s writings, they show that he handled details with care and accuracy. Luke was also a skilled writer and storyteller. He clearly showed how God was at work in the growth of the Christian mission and community.

Luke is one of the most important historians of the ancient world. He wrote after Polybius, often called the last great Greek historian of the 100s BC, and before Eusebius, the first major church historian, who lived from AD 275 to 339.

Place and Date of Writing

The book of Acts was probably written in Rome, but the exact location is unknown.

Many scholars date the writing of Acts after AD 70. They argue this because Luke likely used the Gospel of Mark as a source. Many scholars think Mark was written in the late AD 60s.

However, Acts does not mention several major events from that period, including:

- the result of Paul’s trial, which took place around AD 62;
- the death of James, the brother of Jesus, in the early AD 60s;
- Nero’s persecution of Christians after the fire in Rome in AD 64;
- the deaths of Peter and Paul around AD 64–65;
- the death of Nero in AD 68;
- the Jewish revolt in AD 66; or
- the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70.

Acts ends with Paul living under house arrest in Rome from about AD 60 to 62. Because of this, some scholars argue that Luke wrote Acts before AD 64.

Scholars who date Acts after AD 70 respond that Luke left out these events because they did not serve his purpose. Luke focused instead on how the good news spread outward, from Jerusalem to the wider world (see Acts 1:8; 9:15; 28:31).

Recipients

The book of Acts is the second part of a two-part work (see Luke 1:1–4; Acts 1:1–2). The main recipient of the Gospel of Luke and the book of Acts was Theophilus (Luke 1:3; Acts 1:1). His name means “one who loves God.” Luke calls Theophilus, “most excellent” (Luke 1:3). This is a title also used for Roman governors like Felix and Festus (23:26; 24:2–3; 26:25).

Theophilus may have been Luke’s supporter and sponsor. He was a Gentile who had learned about Christianity (Luke 1:4). Luke wanted him and others to understand Christianity accurately and to extend it throughout the Mediterranean region. This was so they would “know the certainty” about Christianity (Luke 1:4).

Literary Features

The book of Acts presents its material in a careful and precise way (for example, 11:28; 18:2). Archaeology, geography, and related fields of study often support its accuracy. At the same time, Luke writes with energy and vivid detail. This can be seen in scenes such as 5:17–32; 12:1–17; 14:8–20; 16:11–40; and 27:1–44.

Acts also includes major speeches by Peter, Stephen, James, and Paul (2:14–40; 7:2–53; 15:13–21; 22:3–21). The style of these speeches fits their settings well. Peter’s speech at Pentecost has a strong Jewish style (2:14–40). Paul’s speech in Athens reflects a Greek setting and way of speaking (17:22–31). These features show the writer’s literary skill and support the historical character of the book.

Meaning and Message

The book of Acts shows that the Christian faith fulfills (completes and brings to full meaning) God's promises in the Hebrew Scriptures (2:16–36; 4:11–12; 10:42–43; 13:16–41; 17:30–31; see Luke 24:25–27, 44–47). Acts also teaches several key truths:

- Christ brings salvation (rescue from sin and its effects). Jesus is the one through whom God saves people (8:35; 10:36; 16:17, 30–31).
- Prayer helps advance (move forward) God's kingdom (God's rule and reign).

God's people pray together, and God works through their prayers (1:12–15; 2:1–4; 4:24–31; 12:5).

- The Holy Spirit gives power and ability for mission.

The Holy Spirit strengthens God's people and gives them what they need to share the message about Jesus (1:8; 4:8, 31; 6:3, 5, 10; 7:55; 11:24; 13:9, 52).

The book of Acts emphasizes the importance of people God chooses to share his message and testify (speak as witnesses) about Christ. At first, the apostles, especially Peter, spoke about the life and ministry of Jesus (1:22; 10:39–41; see Luke 1:2). Peter explained the role of Jesus in God's plan to save humankind (2:40; 3:15; 4:33; 10:42). Later, other leaders also became witnesses for their Lord. Stephen and Philip are clear examples of courage and faith (7:2–53; 8:4–40).

Other believers also shared their faith whenever they had the opportunity (for example, 8:1–4; 11:19–21). Eventually, God called Paul to join this mission. God described Paul as a “chosen instrument to carry [his] name before the Gentiles and their kings, and before the people of Israel” (9:15; 22:1–21; 26:2–23). Like Peter, Paul becomes a central figure in Acts and a key witness for Christ.

The apostles proclaimed that the death and resurrection of Jesus fulfilled what God had promised in the Scriptures (2:22–36; 3:15; 4:27–28, 33; 7:52; 8:32–35; 10:38–43; 13:26–39). God chose Jesus to save humanity, so the message of the apostles was, “Believe in the Lord Jesus and you will be saved” (16:31). God offers grace and forgives everyone who asks. Then there is “peace through Jesus Christ, who is Lord of all” (10:36). This peace means a restored relationship with God and a new way of life under his rule.

The book of Acts shows that nothing can stop the spread of the gospel of Jesus Christ. The messengers experienced imprisonment, injury, and even death. Despite this, the message spread from a small group in a room in Jerusalem to both Jews and non-Jews across the Roman world (1:12–14). The book of Acts ends with

Paul freely sharing the gospel message at the center of the known world (28:30–31).

Order of Events of the Apostolic Age

Dating events in the time of the apostles can be difficult because the book of Acts does not give many exact dates. However, some events connect to known dates in the Roman world. These connections help us place parts of the story on a timeline (a way to show events in order over time).

Events from AD 30 to 50

Roman sources tell us that Herod Agrippa I died in AD 44 (Acts 12:23). Therefore, his execution of James and imprisonment of Peter occurred before that year (12:2–17).

The “great famine” prophesied by Agabus happened in Judea during the reign of Emperor Claudius (11:28–29). The church in Antioch sent help to the church in Jerusalem. They chose Barnabas and Paul to deliver the money (11:29–30). This was Paul's second visit to Jerusalem after he converted to Christianity. The Jewish historian Josephus places the famine between AD 46 and 48.

While Paul was in Corinth on his second mission, Gallio was proconsul (governor) of Achaia (18:12). An inscription discovered at nearby Delphi shows Gallio served as proconsul from AD 51–52. The event in 18:12–17 probably happened at the start of Gallio's term. Paul then left Corinth soon after, probably in the summer or autumn of AD 52.

Paul had spent 18 months in Corinth (18:11). So he probably arrived in early AD 50. Acts 18:2 confirms this arrival date. When Paul came to Corinth, Aquila and Priscilla had recently been forced to leave (exiled from) Rome. Emperor Claudius ordered Jews to leave Rome in AD 49.

Events from AD 50 to 70

Festus replaced Felix as governor of Judea while Paul was in prison in Caesarea (24:27). This was probably in the summer of AD 59. This event helps us date other events in the book of Acts. They arrested Paul about two years earlier, in AD 57 (21:33). Earlier that spring, Paul celebrated the Passover feast in Philippi (20:6; April AD 57).

Paul had just spent three months in Greece (20:3). This was probably during the winter of AD 56–57 (see 1 Corinthians 16:6). Before that, Paul spent three years in Ephesus (Acts 20:31; AD 53–56).

After Festus arrived in the summer of AD 59, Paul quickly stood trial and appealed to Caesar (25:1-12). The journey to Rome probably began in the fall of AD 59 (27:2). It ended early in AD 60 (28:11-16). Paul stayed in Rome for the next two years (28:30).

The New Testament does not report the outcome of Paul's trial, but he was probably released and then recaptured and martyred in Rome along with Peter and many others during Nero's persecution (around AD 64-65).

In Jerusalem, James the brother of Jesus was stoned to death by the Jewish authorities in AD 62 (Josephus, *Antiquities* 20.9.1). Soon after, the church in Jerusalem left the city and moved to Pella, a city in the Decapolis east of the Jordan River. When war began between the Jews and Romans in AD 66, most Christians avoided the conflict. The war ended in AD 70 when Rome destroyed Jerusalem and the temple.

Events from AD 70 to 100

The New Testament writers and other early Christians left few records of the period following the destruction of Jerusalem. It is possible that both Matthew and Luke wrote after AD 70, but they did not write about the developments that occurred after AD 70.

Similarly, the apostle John probably wrote his gospel and three letters sometime around AD 90. But these writings reveal little about the late AD first-century church. If Revelation was written in the early 90s AD, then it gives us a glimpse of what the churches in Asia Minor were facing during that time (see Revelation Book Introduction, "Date of Writing").

As the time of the apostles came to an end, the church around the Mediterranean Sea continued to grow and develop. This growth did not stop after the last apostles died. Leadership in the church passed on to the next generations, and the church continued to expand and mature (grow stronger and more established).